BUILD CITY × NEAR

TALK 3 · 10:50 · TONY SINGH

BUILD WITH ICM

Interpretable Context Methodology: your folder is the agent’s architecture.

NEAR Private AI Hackathon NYC · Wed 11.11.26

01 / THE PROBLEM

AGENTS GET LOST. FOLDERS FIX IT.

THEY FORGET

Yesterday's work is gone when the chat ends.

THEY WANDER

With everything in context, they drift off the job.

THEY LOCK YOU IN

Your setup lives inside one tool.

Put the instructions in **files and folders**, and any agent finds its way.

THREE LAYERS OF WORKING WITH AI

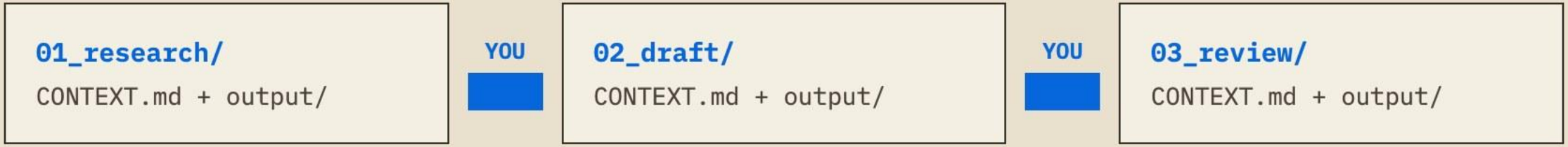
1	**Chat**	Copy, paste, correct
2	**Skills**	Write down what you keep retyping
3	**Folders + one agent**	The AI works inside your files

Most people never leave layer 1. **ICM is layer 3.**

FOR STEP-BY-STEP WORK A PERSON REVIEWS, THE FOLDER STRUCTURE CAN REPLACE THE AGENT FRAMEWORK.

The claim of **Interpretable Context Methodology**, by Jake Van Clief & David McDermott (arXiv:2603.16021, March 2026).

NUMBERED FOLDERS ARE THE STEPS



Numbered folders are the steps

One agent reads the right files at each step

Markdown files hold the instructions and context

You review between steps; state is just files

05 / WHY IT'S WORTH IT

LOAD ONLY WHAT THE STEP NEEDS

2–8k

tokens per step, instead of **~42k** in one giant prompt

Paper estimate

Every step leaves a file you can open and fix before the expensive step

Glass box: you see exactly where a run went wrong

Portable: copy it, zip it, swap the agent. The folder is the memory

Less context is better, not just cheaper: models do worse when the key facts are buried.

Source: Van Clief & McDermott, arXiv:2603.16021

60 / 30 / 10

60

The data, the questions, the thinking: list the steps first

30

Tools you already have: calendar, spreadsheet, scripts

10

The AI

Most people start with the 10. A design reminder, not measured percentages.

PROVE IT IN FOLDERS, THEN BUILD THE APP

1

Run it as folders

Watch which steps come out the same every time

2

Script the steady steps

Done the same way three or four times? Make it a script

3

Contracts become the spec

The proven steps are what your app has to do

ICM is the prototype; the app is the product. (Our advice.)

PICK THE RIGHT TOOL

ICM WINS AT

- Reordering steps
- Editing any step by hand
- Inspecting every result
- Handing it off to someone else

FRAMEWORKS WIN AT

- Automatic retries
- Branching on their own
- Parallel runs
- API integrations

One agent first. Add a second only when you can name the job it removes: most “multi-agent” setups are really instructions plus a map.

Source: Van Clief & McDermott, arXiv:2603.16021 (Table 1)

START FROM YOUR ONE-LINER

Your idea worksheet's **final line** and **feedback** are the brief. In an empty project folder, tell your agent:

PROMPT · FULL VERSION IN THE ICM STARTER GUIDE

Use the icm-architect skill in Build mode. Build me an ICM workspace for: [your final line]. Feedback: [notes]. Ask me your questions a few at a time, then scaffold the smallest workspace that carries the work. Private data runs on a Confidential TEE model. Stop after the scaffold so I can review it.

Have answers ready: what one run works on, where you stop to check, what stays the same every run, what "done" looks like.

A SMALL, READABLE WORKSPACE

```
my-project/
├─ AGENTS.md the map
├─ CONTEXT.md the pipeline
├─ _shared/ stable rules, facts
├─ stages/
│  ├─ 01_intake/
│  ├─ 02_draft/
│  └─ 03_review/
├─ _templates/
└─ _tools/
```

EVERY STAGE'S CONTEXT.MD

Inputs	exact file paths
Process	the numbered steps
Outputs	what it writes, where
Check	you, a script or a small model

Keep AGENTS.md under ~60 lines. One contract plus its inputs under ~8,000 tokens. Three real stages beat seven imagined ones.

Example names · from the icm-architect skill

Build yours today

ANY AGENT THAT CAN READ A FOLDER

Claude Code | Codex | Gemini CLI | **Hermes Agent** | Cursor

GitHub Copilot | OpenCode

The entry file is **AGENTS.md**. Agents that look for CLAUDE.md or GEMINI.md get a one-line pointer to it, so every agent reads the same map.

```
git clone https://github.com/RinDig/icm-architect.git
```

Then put the icm-architect folder in your agent's skills folder. The table is on page 3 of the guide.

ICM-ARCHITECT · MIT

PRIVATE INFERENCE IN FOUR MOVES

1 · Install, open a new terminal

```
curl -fsSL https://hermes-
agent.nousresearch.com/install.sh | bash
```

2 · Your key, typed by you

```
~/.hermes/.env
NEAR_API_KEY=sk-…
```

3 · ~/.hermes/config.yaml

```
model:
  default: "z-ai/glm-5.3-flash"
  provider: "custom"
  base_url: "https://cloud-api.near.ai/v1"
  key_env: NEAR_API_KEY
auth:
  adopt_external_logins: false
```

4 · Add the skill, start in your folder

```
git clone https://github.com/RinDig/icm-
architect.git ~/.hermes/skills/icm-architect
mkdir my-project && cd my-project && git init
hermes
```

Test with **hermes -z "Say hello in one sentence."** · restart Hermes after you change AGENTS.md · all 9 steps: ICM starter guide, page 4.

WRITE THE MODEL INTO THE CONTRACT

TOUCHES PRIVATE DATA

stages/02_analyze/CONTEXT.md

model: z-ai/glm-5.3-flash

A Confidential TEE model, always

PUBLIC DATA ONLY

stages/03_format/CONTEXT.md

model: any you like

Pick by cost and quality

The choice sits where a person can see it. And remember: **only the model call is private.** Your agent, your laptop and the files it sends sit outside the TEE.

WHEN NOT TO USE ICM

Real-time teams of agents

Agents talking to each other live

Many users at once

High-concurrency serving needs real code

Branching on its own

Workflows that must decide their next step

No retries, scheduling, deployment or model router built in: you add those with a script or a tool. The paper says so itself, and its evidence is still early: informal, self-reported, a self-selected community.

Source: Van Clief & McDermott, arXiv:2603.16021

BUILD YOUR WORKSPACE TODAY

ICM starter guide

In the hackpack, Builders Cafe WhatsApp

icm-architect skill

github.com/RinDig/icm-architect

Questions? Grab me as I walk around, or ask in the chats

ICM was created by **Jake Van Clief & David McDermott**

Learn it free: **Clief Notes** community on Skool